

Out of Place, In the Body: The Personal Dimension of Orientalism

Edward Said begins his landmark text, *Orientalism*, by explaining and critiquing the ways in which the West constructs and dominates the East through discourse. In the introduction, Said identifies a “personal dimension” that informs and complicates his understanding of the subject he analyzes. That personal dimension refers to his lived experience as an “Oriental” under Western institutions.¹ In *Out of Place*, Said expands on the personal dimension by showing how colonial dominance defined not only his worldview and intellectual thinking, but also his embodied experiences of exile, shame, self-surveillance, and illness. The theoretical aspects of *Orientalism* are drawn from his physical, emotional, and sensory accounts of displacement. Said brings *Orientalism* and the personal dimension to life through *Out of Place*, and in doing so, he shows how imperial power operates through the body—disciplining, shaming, and fracturing it. In this essay, I argue that one way *Out of Place* fills in the personal dimension of *Orientalism* is through grounding Said’s theoretical ideas in the lived experience of the body. Through recollection of his racialized body—its appearance, sexual shame, awkwardness, fragmentation and illnesses—Said illustrates displacement as an experience governed by physical and colonial control. By centering the embodiment of Orientalism, the memoir demonstrates how the violence of

¹ Edward W. Said, *Orientalism* (New York: Vintage Books, 1979), 25.

colonialism is felt personally; it is marked upon the very flesh and psyche of those it subjugates.

Said, a Palestinian born pre-Nakba, grows up between cultures: he hails from Jerusalem, but spends many of his formative years in and out of American and British colonial schools in Cairo. Amid this cultural dislocation, the anxieties and expectations of his overbearing parents become a central force shaping his relationship to his body and sense of self, which play a pivotal role in his formative development. The nearly absurd demands imposed by Said's parents include wearing trusses on his back, cutting his curls, and abandoning his glasses, subjecting him to constant physical discipline. Said internalizes these pressures deeply, expressing, "I felt seriously unwilling to let myself be looked at, so conscious was I of innumerable physical defects, all of which I was convinced reflected my inner deformations. To be looked at directly, and to return the gaze, was most difficult for me."² Although this scrutiny comes from Said's parents rather than imperial power directly, their attitudes towards Said's body reflect the broader colonial culture in which they were raised as well as the Western standards of the time. In this way, we can understand his parents as agents of colonial authority, enforcing the rigid ideas of strength and control onto Said's body. It is clear how the colonial gaze infiltrates the most intimate spaces: family, the body,

² Edward W. Said, *Out of Place: A Memoir* (New York: Knopf, 1999), 55.

and self-perception. The racialized body, and specifically Said's body, is represented as a contested site where power is imposed through correction, punishment, and surveillance, reinforcing the structures of hierarchy that Said critiques in *Orientalism*.

Said's awareness of his body as marked and divided is clear in the sense that his appearance set him apart, making him feel out of place even within his own family. He begins chapter four comparing his "shrinking, nervous timidity and shyness" with his father Wadie's "strength, moral and physical" which "dominated the early part of [his] life."³ While Wadie is depicted as the ideal masculine, domineering and muscular, Said's mother Hilda serves as a foil to this perfect masculinity, embodying femininity, elegance, and beauty. These two standards mirror the Orientalist binaries imposed on the colonized body and identity, which Said experiences firsthand not only through his time in colonial schools, but through his own family. Just as colonial power constructs rigid categories of strength, weakness, and otherness, Said's family imposes contrasting ideals that he struggles to embody. His looks manifest as a physical dissonance from his cultural background. Said even points out that he feels out of place from his own family in regards to their appearance: "I noticeably resembled neither the Said's (short, stocky, very dark) nor her family, the Musas (white-skinned, of medium height and

³ Ibid.

build, with longer than average fingers and limbs).”⁴ Said highlights how his body does not fit into the familial or gender categories that define his sense of belonging. Later on, Said even describes one of his fantasies, “to be a book...happily free of unwelcome changes, distortions of its shape, criticism of its looks.”⁵ Here, it is revealed that his ultimate wish is to be disembodied from his appearance and self. When we understand these standards as imposed on Said through displacement, Said’s experience reveals how Orientalism operates not only through external political domination but also through the internalized, bodily dimensions of exile. The memoir fleshes out *Orientalism*’s theoretical insights and personal dimension by grounding them in the lived, corporeal experience of colonial subjugation.

A central theme of *Out of Place* is Said’s education, which is represented in many different schools and places. Across these various transnational settings, a consistent tension remains: a fragmented sense of identity and belonging produced by displacement. From British and American schools in Cairo to prestigious universities in the United States, Said’s feelings as an Oriental manifest itself through the policing of his body, his insecurities, and his efforts to conform. One example of the physical discipline and bodily subjugation Said endured during his schooling years takes place at GPS (Gezira Preparatory School) in Cairo. He recounts a particularly humiliating encounter with Mr. Bullen, a teacher who beat

⁴ Ibid., 67.

⁵ Ibid., 76.

Said with a cane, leaving him physically pained and deeply aware of his vulnerability. The power dynamics between Said and Mr. Bullen are especially disproportionate. Said is only eight years old at the time, while Mr. Bullen is described as a “large, red-faced, sandy-haired and silent Englishman,”⁶ making the encounter all the more traumatic. The incident left a lasting impression on Said’s understanding of authority as he describes it as his first “experience of an organized system set up as a colonial business by the British.”⁷ Here, Said’s body is subjected to the direct regulation of Western dominance in a way that differs from his other experiences under control. The discipline of his body is overt and publicly administered in the clash with Mr. Bullen, confronting him directly with the power of colonial structures.

Given the fact that Said suffered years of his parents’ relentless judgement and lived through many different cultural contexts, it should not be surprising that at a very young age he learned to harshly regulate his appearance, even as he pursued intellectual development. Said reflects on this tension, noting that being “never at home or at least at Mount Hermon, out of place in nearly every way, gave me the incentive to find my territory, not socially but intellectually.”⁸ There is a juxtaposition between Said’s sense of belonging while at Mount Hermon: he began

⁶ Ibid., 41.

⁷ Ibid., 42.

⁸ Ibid., 231.

to form his academic identity and interests, yet he is still constantly aware of his differences. Mount Hermon is a significant setting in *Out of Place* because it highlights the intersection of Said's cultural otherness, exile, and identity formation. The distance from his homeland and his native culture—which he already feels disconnected from—intensifies his sense of being a Palestinian and Arab outsider. Said writes, “Clothes were a problem for me. Everyone wore corduroys, jeans, lumber jackets, boots... I had to write to my parents to get permission to buy a more appropriate wardrobe and by October I was almost but not quite like everyone else.”⁹

Despite his attempts at assimilation, he remains seen as different. Clothing is a physical and bodily reminder of his outsider status. Even mundane aspects of daily life, such as getting dressed, are marked by constant self-surveillance and the pressure to adhere to Western standards. It is also interesting to note Said's need to write to his parents for approval. This represents the layers of external control and internalized judgment that shaped, or rather damaged, his sense of self. Such dynamics are ultimately rooted in dominant structures of Orientalism, where power imposes rigid categories of identity. Said, as a Palestinian-born, American and British-educated, and exiled individual, who, at this point of *Out of Place*, is being educated in New England, feels these standards to the extreme. The contrast

⁹ Ibid., 234.

between striving to belong while feeling out of place mirrors the effects of colonialism and the universal Palestinian experience of displacement, thus filling the personal dimension that Said touches on in *Orientalism*. Said's pedagogical journey is inseparable from the discipline of his body, where his ambitions unfold alongside a painful negotiation with his appearance and self.

One of the more explicit moments in Said's narrative focuses on his introduction to sexuality, where his intimate body becomes subject both to parental regulation and colonial power. Sex is framed as an act of shame, disgust, and prohibition. Both Said's schools in Cairo and the United States had "infantilized and desexualized everything,"¹⁰ which occurred alongside his parents' reinforcement of sexual repression. Perhaps most notable in Said's recollection of bodily control is a confrontation between Said and his parents when Said is fourteen years old. Said recalls ambiguous mentions of sex through "man-to-man talks,"¹¹ where his father lectures him on masturbation. However, this instruction is less about education than about instilling fear and shame, positioning Said's emerging sexuality as something to be controlled and hidden. In the instance between Said and both his mother and father, Said's parents reprimand him for allegedly masturbating, which they refer euphemistically to as "self-abuse."¹²

¹⁰ Ibid., 69.

¹¹ Ibid., 70.

¹² Ibid.

Engaging with sexuality, particularly masturbation, is presented as both morally and physically dangerous.

Though sexual repression is quite common throughout the different contexts that Said grows up in, it is important to connect these examples of bodily control to the Orientalist structures which he later defines. Said's early experiences under the surveillance of his body left a lasting imprint on his psyche: "I was seized with such terror, guilt, shame and vulnerability that I have never forgotten this scene."¹³ Just as his parents depicted sexuality as shameful, the Orientalist construction of the East similarly disciplines the "Other" through the lens of sexuality, marking non-Western bodies as exotic and in need of control. He begins *Orientalism* by showing how the Orient is routinely described as feminine, with a major symbol being the sensual Eastern woman.¹⁴ This sexualization of the Orient aligns with the moralization of sexuality Said describes in his memoir. Both Said's emerging sexuality and the Oriental body are subjected to systems of control. Sexuality therefore functions as a tool for asserting hierarchy and power over racialized and colonized bodies. The brutal scoldings he suffers in *Out of Place* supports Said's arguments in *Orientalism* by showing how the regulation of sex is deeply rooted in cultural domination.

¹³ Ibid., 72.

¹⁴ Said, *Orientalism*, 6.

Said's sexual experiences are directly symptomatic of his being out of place. Another example of this is his relationship with Eva, an American woman whose cultural background represents a world that is out of reach for Said. He describes their relationship as marked by intense desire, but also unpredictability and emotional constraint. He writes, "At times, she represented that aspect of an ideal America that I could never gain admission to, but which held me enthralled at the gate."¹⁵ Said is drawn to her physically and romantically, yet is constantly reminded of the cultural boundaries imposed on the relationship. Like his childhood, where parental and societal forces regulated his sexuality, Said's relationship with Eva reinforced his feelings of alienation. Because his earlier conceptions of intimacy are so damaged, Said cannot fully engage in desire or trust. His romantic relationships are instead filled with feelings of exclusion, insecurity, and self-surveillance, thus echoing the broader dynamics of displacement and otherness that shape his life. The tensions between East and West are very clear here, as Said's physical and romantic experience with an American woman mirror the cultural and geopolitical divides he later theorizes in *Orientalism*. The inability to fully belong reflects the ways in which the "Other" is constructed, constrained, and measured against dominant Western norms.

¹⁵ Said, *Out of Place*, 282.

A final point of interest in my exploration of Said, the personal dimension, and the Oriental body is the role of his illness in recounting his life. His fatal diagnosis can be interpreted as a metaphor for displacement, representing the body's internalization of colonial and familial discipline. It also operates as an inherited and relational condition, seen in the parallels between Said and his mother's citizenship struggle, prolonged illness, and eventual death. Both bodies bear marks of repression and displacement that define much of the Palestinian experience. While *Orientalism* defines imperial domination as an external system of power and knowledge, *Out of Place* illustrates this argument by revealing how such domination is also internal and lived.

The autobiography therefore does more than simply bear out his earlier argument in *Orientalism*; it deepens it, showing how the legacies of colonial power persist through generations, shaping the body, the family, and the very conditions of being. However, the genre of *Out of Place* should be seen as more than just a memoir: it also functions as critical work in both literary theory and postcolonial discourse. In it, Said demonstrates that the effects of Orientalism are not only external but physical and embodied, blurring the line between personal vulnerability and political condition. His theoretical framework in *Orientalism* cannot be fully understood within discourse analysis alone. Instead, it must be understood through *Out of Place* and the personal dimension—which in one way

manifests itself through bodily and physical experiences. By grounding his intellectual ideas in the lived and sensory realities of his childhood and adulthood—through the disembodiment of shame, illness, and ultimately, exile—Said turns the critical gaze inward, showing how the “Oriental” is not only produced and constructed by empire but also inscribed upon the body itself.

Bibliography

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